

Communities of Practice

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Abstract

Objectives: We sought to determine what early learning professionals know about communities of development and if they are being implemented. If communities of practice are being used, we wanted to gain insight on how they are being implemented.

Methods: We conducted a survey that was sent to early learning professionals via e-mail who were invited to attend the communities of practice symposium. We attended the Communities of Practice Symposium and lead groups to address concerns and issues that the professionals wanted to address that were occurring in their agency or as a professional.

Results: Participants demonstrated their knowledge on communities of practice in the survey before the symposium. At the symposium, participants addressed professional issues and concerns that they have and began a community of practice.

Conclusions: Early learning professionals generally have a good understanding of communities of practice and use the process in their agency. The professionals demonstrated an interest in gaining more insight on professional development and building more communities of practice to enhance their work with children.

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Introduction

Collaborating Agencies

Calgary and Area Child and Family Services (CFSA) mission is to “protect, serve, and enhance the well-being of vulnerable children, youth and families, through engaging our communities and leading in the creation and delivery of services” (Calgary and Area, 2009). The authority’s mandate is that “each child, youth, and family we serve lives with dignity, a sense of belonging, and hope for the future” (Calgary and Area, 2009).

In relation to their mandate, CFSA has partnered with Mount Royal Child Studies students to work on a project exploring communities of practice. They have examined issues such as how the term ‘communities of practice’ has been understood, what types of strategies have been utilized, and finally what the successful outcomes were as well as barriers that have affected communities of practice in the past.

CFSA is also working with Mount Royal Child Studies students to carry out a survey for employees practicing in the community. Collaborators of this study include the Department of Child and Youth Studies at Mount Royal College, Joanne Baxter and Cathy Smey Carston.

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of the study is to determine what communities of practice is in terms of early learning professionals, what early learning practitioners know about communities of practice, if or how they implement them in their work, and educate them on communities of practice and strategies to implement in their work.

Definition of Terms

“Communities of practice are groups of people who share a concern or a passion for something they do and learn how to do it better as they interact regularly” (Wenger, n.d.). Communities of practice have three characteristics that are essential: the domain, community, and practice. In communities of practice there needs to be a common domain of interest and therefore being a member implies that you are committed to the domain (Wenger, n.d.). The community includes practitioner members who participate in activities and discussions help each other, and share information, which leads to relationship building that results in the members learning from each other (Wenger, n.d.). The practice includes practitioner members and they develop a shared collection of resources, such as, experiences, stories, tools, and ways of addressing recurring problems (Wenger, n.d.).

There are other terms that are related to communities of practice, which include collaborative learning communities, professional learning communities, and learning circles. Collaborative learning uses small groups of people who encourage each other to maximize their own and each other’s learning (Tu, 2004, p. 12). Sharing one’s ideas and responding to others’ improves thinking and deepens understanding” (Tu, 2004, p. 13). In collaborative learning communities there are four important issues that must be considered: empowering learners, building communities, continuing support, and being patient (Tu, 2004, p. 13). Professional learning communities have seven components, a shared belief, value, and vision, shared and supportive leadership, collective learning and applying the knowledge, supportive conditions, and shared personal practice (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p. 8-15). Learning circles are small communities of people who come together to support each other in learning (Collay, Dunlap, Enloe &Gagnon, 1998, p. 2). Learning circles are usually informal and based on work,

friendships, or neighbourhood relationships among people who share the same interests, do similar things, or interact with each other regularly (Collay et al, 1998, p. 3).

Limitations of the Study

Limitations of this study include limited time and limited sample size. Time is a limitation because even though we sent the survey to the individuals who were attending the symposium later, we are unable to have a personal meeting with each individual to get a better understanding of what they think communities of practice is and if they think they use it in their workplace due to time constraints. Sample size is also a limitation to the study because there are only a certain number of people who are attending the symposium; therefore, we only have a small sample size of all early learning professionals.

Significance of the Study

This study is significant because we are researching what the benefit of communities of practice is for early childhood learning professionals and if they use it in the work that they do. It is important to educate early learning professionals on communities of practice because these practitioners are working with children and it is important for the practitioners to build communities of practice in order to enhance their knowledge and the children's development that they are working with.

Communities of Practice has proven beneficial to other professional fields, it is then also important to see whether communities of practice will benefit early childhood learning professionals as well.

Research Question

In order to gather all the information on the topic of Communities of Practice it was essential to come up with a research question to guide the project: What is the knowledge and implementation of Communities of Practice by early learning professionals?

Communities of Practice – Literature Review

Introduction

Communities of Practice is often a term that most people are unfamiliar with until they are given the opportunity to further explore how it is related to their profession. It is anticipated that by researching communities of practice, early childhood learning professionals will have the tools and resources to complete their job both effectively and efficiently.

The purpose of this literature review is to explore first, the term and meanings of “communities of practice”, second the success and challenges of implementation and finally, strategies that are being drawn on and applied.

Communities of Practice

“Communities of practice are groups of people who share a concern or a passion for something they do and learn how to do it better as they interact regularly” (Wenger, n.d.). There are three essential characteristics in defining communities of practice:

- 1.) *The domain*: There needs to be a common domain of interest and therefore being a member implies that you are committed to the domain. The members value their shared competence and learn from each other, even though there may only be a couple people who even realize that they have expertise on the topic (Wenger, n.d.).

- 2.) *The community*: The members participate in activities and discussions, help each other, and share information, which leads to relationship building that results in the members learning from each other. A community of practice is not simply having the same job as someone, unless the members interact and learn together (Wenger, n.d.).
- 3.) *The practice*: Members are practitioners and they develop a shared collection of resources, such as experiences, stories, tools, and ways of addressing recurring problems (Wenger, n.d.). Everyone has different experiences and can bring different opinions and suggestions to the group.

Even though all communities of practice have the three elements of a domain, community, and practice, there are many different forms of communities (Wenger, n.d.). Some are small and others are large with usually with a core group and many peripheral members. Communities can also be local, worldwide, meet face-to-face or online. Communities can practice within an organization, some have members from different organizations, and some are formally recognized with a budget while others are informal and invisible (Wenger, n.d.). Communities of practice are closely related to theories of collaborative learning communities, professional learning communities, and learning circles. Therefore, a community of practice is a group of professionals who come together to work towards a common goal by sharing their expertise and knowledge on the topic.

Collaborative Learning Communities

A community of practice is closely related to collaborative learning. Collaborative learning engages small groups of people who encourage each other to maximize their own and each other's learning (Tu, 2004, p. 12). Collaborative learning engages learners in knowledge sharing, inspiring each other, depending upon each other, and applying active social interaction

in a small group. “In all situations where people come together in groups suggests a way of dealing with people, which respects and highlights individual group members’ abilities and contributions” (Tu, 2004, p. 12). Members of the group share authority and take on responsibilities to benefit the group. “Good learning, like good work, is collaborative and social, not competitive and isolated. Sharing one’s ideas and responding to others’ improves thinking and deepens understanding” (Tu, 2004, p. 13). In collaborative learning communities there are four important issues that must be considered: empowering learners, building communities, continuing support, and being patient (Tu, 2004, p. 13).

Professional Learning Communities

Professional learning communities are closely related to communities of practice. Hord & Sommers (2008, p. 10) states that there are five components of professional learning communities:

- 1.) *Shared Beliefs, Values, and Vision:* A model in education is that the members of the group consistently focus on the child’s learning, which is strengthened by the members of the group continuously sharing expertise and learning from each other. When being a member of a community of practice, every individual’s values and beliefs influence the people’s behaviours no matter where they work or what type of situation they are in (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p.8). As a result, it is important to have a common purpose, including a mission and goal that everyone agrees with. Everyone is encouraged to participate in creating the vision and to keep it in their minds while planning and directly working with the children. The vision leads to the way early learning professional work and interact with children. Even though each individual is responsible for their own actions, the common good for children is considered to be equivalent with the

individuals' personal ambitions “The individuals become a community whose common purpose is the high-quality learning of all students” (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p. 10).

- 2.) *Shared and Supportive Leadership:* All early learning professionals have the same amount of power and authority to make decisions in a community of practice. “One of the defining characteristics of professional learning communities is that power, authority, and decision making are shared and encouraged” (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p.10). People involved in the professional learning community need to talk with one another about their practice, share their knowledge about the topic, observe each other while they are engaged in their practice, and encourage each other to be successful in order to build cooperative interactions (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p. 11).
- 3.) *Collective Learning and Its Application:* People involved in professional learning communities are continually learning together and applying what they have learned to their work. “The major emphasis is on collective learning, when individuals learn more than if they are learning independently. The professional learning community is not just about collaboration; it is collaborating to learn together about a topic the community deems important” (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p.12). Learning communities that are successful share all their knowledge with each other which enhances possibilities for the community's vision (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p. 12).
- 4.) *Supportive Conditions:* There are two types of supportive conditions, structural factors and relational factors. Structural factors provide the physical requirements to support collaboration, like, time, and resources. Relational factors support the community's human and interpersonal development, openness, truth telling, and focusing on attitudes of respect and caring among the members (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p. 9).

- 5.) *Shared Personal Practice*: Community members give and receive feedback to show their improvement as an individual and as a group. Once everyone is comfortable with the group and is able to trust everyone, people are more comfortable sharing their successes and failures. These positive relationships will lead to the group members praising and recognizing each other's triumphs, and offer empathy and support for each other's struggles (Hord & Sommers, 2008, p. 15).

Learning Circles

“Learning circles are small communities of learners among teachers and others who come together intentionally for the purpose of supporting each other in the process of learning” (Collay, Dunlap, Enloe & Gagnon, 1998, p. 2). Learning circles can be short term or long term, but they must be healthy communities of learners to separate themselves from workshops, in-service sessions, or reform efforts. Healthy learners are professionals who can be dedicated to their work but also be able to separate themselves when they leave work. Learning circles are usually informal and based on work, friendships, or neighbourhood relationships among people who share the same interests, do similar things, or interact with each other regularly (Collay et al, 1998, p. 3).

Examples of Communities of Practice

Communities of Practice is a new term for early learning professionals but not in concept. The idea of professionals coming together has had a pre-existing history of being carried out in several different ways.

In New Zealand Educational Leadership Project (ELP) was put together in 2000 to provide professional development to support the curriculum in early childhood education settings

(Lee, 2008). There were two parts to the ELP project. The first was Assessing Children's Experiences in Early Learning Childhood Settings. This project developed a framework of learning stories and promoted documentation of children's learnings (Lee, 2008). The first project came to the conclusion that not only should skills be available but funds for knowledge too (Lee, 2008). The second part of the project was the Early Childhood Learning and Assessment "Exemplar" Project. This project determined different ways of implementing the curriculum (Lee, 2008). These two projects directed the Learning Story Framework to help teachers adapt their communities in a way that best reflected their values (Lee, 2008).

The ELP consists of workshops, retreats, visits to centers, research, end of year presentations, transition projects, Information Communications Technology innovation, national and international conferences and inspiration days (Lee, 2008). By using these forms of professional development ELP can provide a solid foundation to build an organization that works on values, beliefs and assumption through dialogue and where teachers' interest and passion is nurtured (Lee, 2008). Lee (2008) also states that ELP is a multifaceted paradigm that has been successfully incorporated providing an experience that empowers the leadership in teaching communities.

In 1940 Lady Gowrie Child Centers in Australia established a program in early childhood that shared project work, information, resources and forms of training (Colmer, 2008). Changes in social policies have provided difficulties in the past with the integrated programs but a center in Adelaide is making great efforts to move back to the way it was in 1940 (Colmer, 2008). Where resources, information, project work and training are shared rather than kept to the program. Colmer (2008) believes that in order for staff to develop skills and knowledge as well as have a more dynamic work setting it should be done by the integration of various programs.

Having access to these highly specialized early learning expertise and knowledge will enrich the work setting (Colmer, 2008).

In order for integrated programs to happen Colmer (2008) suggests five different steps that should take place in order to do so. The first is to lead a dynamic learning organization. This means that there should be a presence of training that is easily accessed and available to all employees within the centre (Colmer, 2008). The second is managing. The leader within the organization needs to know how to engage their team and when to use these additional measures to achieve goals (Colmer, 2008). Therefore the leader needs to develop strategies and management skills in order to motivate team members (Lee, 2008). The third is to motivate and inspire staff through shared leadership and reflectivity. Leaders need to nurture staff members through motivation, passion and high energy levels (Colmer, 2008). A development of formal systems of mentoring and peer support will help in the development of staff (Colmer, 2008). The fourth is to create developed leadership structures and engage with complexity. Being mindful of the issues of childcare pay, conditions, resentment or low self-esteem from working along side teachers with superior pay and conditions then theirs is essential (Colmer, 2008). Acknowledgement of staff contributions through awards and qualifications enables staff to be proactive in their career (Colmer, 2008). The last step is developing an early years center as an effective learning network. Encouragement of staff member to become qualified trainers and train other early childhood staff members provides links to training centers and children's programs as well as a link to other professionals (Colmer, 2008). By implementing these five techniques a learning community can develop and function self-sufficiently.

Another form of communities of practice was the program National Professional Qualification in Integrated Center Leadership (NPQICL). NPQICL was developed when the UK

government launched a new training program for early years leaders in 2004 (Whalley et al, 2008). In 2005-2006 the program consisted of eight different universities, affiliated regional leadership center and children's centers working with 380 participants in 15 learning communities (Whalley et al, 2008). In this program the Pen Green Research Training and Development center was responsible for supporting tutors/mentors, developing/providing a systematic and sustainable approach to quality assurance and continuous quality improvement (Whalley et al, 2008). Researchers wanted to know if early learning professionals found strengths and weaknesses in this mentor/tutoring pilot (Whalley et al, 2008). After the pilot had been conducted and the data was collected it was concluded that the NPQICL program had proved strong enough to be successful in a range of contexts (Whalley et al, 2008).

These previously achieved, attempted and piloted programs similar to the concept of communities of practice have laid the foundation and given valuable information to anyone who is interested to start a communities of practice in their area.

Successes

Success within the community is what makes members decide whether or not they want to continue with the idea of communities of practice. Saint-Onge & Wallace (2003) state that members will have an enriched sense of confidence and feel supported if they know their questions will be answered. Success relies on whether the members have an ownership within the community and have an opportunity to become a leader (Saint-Onge & Wallace, 2003).

When a dispute or conflicts arise among members it is important to deal with it in a respectful and timely fashion productively rather than punitively (Saint-Onge & Wallace, 2003). When issues are dealt with in this fashion members are likely to feel less resentful and are more

willing to return as opposed to feeling frustrated. Leaders of the group tend to build a larger vision when there is a desire in the team's learning and commitment (Colmer, 2008).

These are the skills and characteristics to become a successful community of practice but there are also some success stories in the implementation of the concept.

Some areas have used the previously discussed successful ways of working with the community and its members. Lee (2008) highlights how a teacher has responded to Educational Leadership project (ELP), a form of communities of practice:

I am passionate about teaching and learning and have been excited about the journey through ELP and making a difference in children's lives. A wonderful forum for listening, reflecting, making sense of current research, shifting practice in light of new understandings, sharing ideas and being innovative. My practice has changed in light of research and I feel better equipped in sharing my pedagogy. (p. 98)

The tutor participants in the NPQICL program thought the program was a great experience, felt a strong sense of togetherness, enjoyed working in a group, enjoyed the experience of containment and challenge and saw this opportunity as a profound level of professional development (Whalley et al, 2008, pp. 35). One participant states, " Within the learning group there is the opportunity to explore and challenge at whatever level I felt comfortable with – it is supportive, nurturing and I felt very involved and encouraged" (Whalley et al, 2008, pp. 36). According to Williams (2006) the NPQICL pilot's participants rated the approach one hundred percent for providing academic challenge and ninety-seven percent in a significant change in practice (as cited in Whalley et al, 2008). This shows that a structure of

communities of practice is useful to working professionals and that they find it helpful to their careers.

Challenges

In every great idea there are always a few challenges. Although communities of practice is a newer concept, there have been some challenges and failures noted. One is that every so often a coordinator can weaken a community's success (Wenger, McDermott S Snyder, 2002). Common reasons for the coordinator's failure may consist of time, public space versus private space, networking skills and technical knowledge (Wenger et al, 2002).

A common concern for communities of practice is that it can become a clique. Clique communities can become a dominate and powerful unit that become exclusive by the tightness of the relationships causing a resistance to critiquing each other or prevent members from seeking to deepen their understanding (Wenger et al, 2002). Wegner et al (2002) also state that the community that is developed can have hundreds if not thousands of individuals coming together and the likelihood of you making close relationships with everyone is not likely at all. This can become a factor in that the size can take away from the general idea of bringing people together to build off of one another.

From the implementation of the concepts of *communities of practice* there have been some challenges noted. Based on the NPQICL program Williams (2006) concluded that if the mentors or tutors are not successful in bring the learning out in group work or relating it theoretical practices to people's experiences then the quality begins to disappear (as cited in Whalley et al, 2008).

Another concern that the pilot NPQICL program brought forth was that some of the participants may have been influenced by peers or employers requesting them to attend which in

turn could have caused problems with the delivery (Whalley et al, 2008). If these tutors or mentors are forced into participating, their commitment will not be there and they may not share the vision of the program (Whalley et al, 2008). Also if these people are forced to come they may not share the experiences they have or there may be no experiences at all to share therefore lowering the quality of delivery (Whalley et al, 2008). Mentors or even participants being subjected to attend by an employer can promote negative feelings about the experience or a change in their attitude about the motive to attend in the first place.

There is no sure way of avoiding all the challenges that may arise in a group of professionals coming together especially when it is people you are working with. The focus then does not need to be how you can avoid any challenges but learning about them and developing positive and helpful ways of dealing with them

Strategies in Communities of Practice

What are the different kinds of strategies that are being drawn on and applied in communities of practice? The following are five key strategies that have been identified and explored further: create an equal environment, keep material and activities engaging, establish a routine, embrace third party opinions, and design for growth and expansion.

Create an equal environment - Communities of practice is structured in a way that if no cooperation existed among professionals, the practice itself would not exist at all. In this type of practice, everyone must feel comfortable speaking during discussions and no one should be left feeling intimidated. This means leaving egos at the door and finding a way to work together to achieve together. Wenger (2002) states that “engaging all players is essential to getting a good start for any community. Overcoming conflicting priorities and developing a common understanding of the potential value of the community typically takes extensive preparation”.

Keep material and activities engaging - Many professionals who become involved with communities of practice are doing so in their spare time. A community of practice doesn't have to be dull, dry and boring. Creating excitement by exploring different activities that professionals can use in their own agency or discussing topics that are of interest to everyone will keep members motivated to come back for more.

“Successful communities of practice provide enough structured activities for members to build a pace of participation; however, they also provide opportunities for members to share creative ideas and opportunities” (Wenger, 2002).

Establish a Routine - Members in communities of practice will appreciate that a routine is laid out on what will be accomplished during each meeting and when. Every member that joins a community of practice will have different schedules and hours that they are committed by. By having a routine in place, members are more able to work around their commitments if necessary and a more smooth running communities of practice can take place (Wenger, 2002).

Embrace third party opinions: While it is important to have professional attitudes part of a community of practice, it is equally important to have third party opinions as well. Third party opinions are people who are not part of the practice but serve as a significant role to how things are decided within. Third parties may serve as a neutral voice about what the community is looking for, what is lacking, or what has been overdone and tried in the past.

“Good design for communities of practice requires both insider and outsider perspectives. Insiders understand the key issues and barriers to problem-solving and may have the knowledge required to help the community move forward. Outsiders who are not experts on the issue may serve as neutral facilitators to help members see new possibilities” (Wenger, 2002).

Design for growth and expansion: One of the issues that communities of practice must prepare for is the growth and expansion with the community itself. As time evolves, new information will be introduced as well as new ideas and techniques that could be incorporated into the practice. Wenger (2002) points out that “as community grows, new members bring new interests and may pull the focus of the community in different directions. Changes in the organization influence the relative importance of the community and place new demands on it”.

Create an equal environment, keep material and activities engaging, and establish a routine, embrace third party opinions, and design for growth and expansion are five different strategies that have been utilized in communities of practice.

Methods

Context

This project is about communities of practice. We are researching the knowledge around what early learning professionals know about communities of practice. The problem is that we are not sure how much knowledge early learning professionals have on communities of practice and if they are using various strategies in their work to benefit themselves and the children they are working with.

Research Question and Design

In order to gather information on the topic of Communities of Practice it was essential to come up with a research question to guide the project: What is the knowledge and implementation of Communities of Practice by early learning professionals? From speaking to the project leader it was clear that CFSA wanted to know what individuals in the field already knew about that concept of Communities of Practice. Through research it is the goal to grasp the

knowledge that these individuals have and to understand how they might already be implementing their own forms of Communities of Practice. In order to begin to develop an answer to this question there were three other research questions that needed to be answered. The first question was to define what Communities of Practice is and the other definitions that are used related to this same concept. The second question was: what are some examples of Communities of Practice and what were their success and challenges? The final focus research question was what are some specific approaches in the development of Communities of Practice? (Personal Communication, Cathy Carston, Research Coordinator, January 21, 2009). These questions were preliminary understandings of professionals.

Once these questions have been addressed the research begins to take another path. The focus questions then will address the needs of the early learning professionals in the form of a survey and then focus groups were conducted at the Communities of Practice conference. How can they implement successful Communities of Practice? What will be the benefits of engaging in Communities of Practice? What are the challenges of engaging in Communities of Practice? (Personal Communication, Cathy Smey Carston, Research Coordinator, January 21, 2009). This research project looks at two different aspects to Communities of Practice, the information that is already out there and how to deliver it to the professionals.

In order to answer these questions there was a distinct plan set forth. The first task decided was to meet with the research coordinator (Cathy Carston) to get a better understanding of what was being asked of the research students. It was important to get an understanding of the concepts before the initial research began. A contract was then drawn up with specific tasks to be completed. First on the contract was to complete the literature review. In order to accomplish this, meetings were set up with the research coordinator to guide and answer questions as well as

narrow down the focus. Once the research was complete from the literature review then the meetings began for the survey. A survey was set up to be distributed within the last week of February /first week of March. This is where most of the answers came from about what the early learning professionals already know or don't know and what they may see as a barrier or strength in engaging in Communities of Practice. Once surveys came back the data was collected in time for the conference that took place in mid March. The researchers then conduct focus groups at the conference.

Early learning professionals took part in the survey online anonymously when it was distributed by email. The sample population was chosen from professionals who had registered for the conference in mid March.

Ethical Considerations

Some of the ethical considerations when conducting a complete survey online for communities of practice are:

- *Population Sample Size:* The sample size of the survey consisted of an estimated twenty employees. Of those employees, all were asked to provide an additional three employees they personally felt would benefit this survey.
- *Right to Privacy:* Participants in the communities of practice survey were able to choose which questions they wanted to answer. If they decided not to answer specific questions, they were not penalized in any way for it. Their full participation in the symposium was welcomed.
- *Voluntary Participation:* Surveys were sent out to participants' emails and they were asked to voluntarily fill it out before the symposium. Whether they decided to participate in the survey or not did not affect their eligibility to participate in the symposium.

- *Informed Consent:* Participants did not agree formally to participate in the survey because it was assumed when they signed up for the symposium. Participants were still able to refuse participation to the survey if they wish since it was voluntary.
- *Confidentiality:* All data to the survey will be kept private and only be seen by research students analysing the data to report as findings as well as collaborators who are working with the students. Any information, comments, or questions participants decided to comment on was strictly confidential and anonymous.
- *Ethics Approval:* Ethics approval was not needed as the survey was an integral part of the conference.

Data Collection

In order to collect the data in this research project there are two different types of collection procedures. The first is to administer a survey (Appendix B) to early learning professionals who are already registered to attend the Symposium in March. This survey was sent via email and consisted of qualitative and quantitative questions. The survey is eighteen questions long and consisted of multiple choice questions and long answer questions. The data was collected in time to have a general understanding on where the participants stand in their understanding of Communities of Practice. The survey gave specific information about the target population that may utilize Communities of Practice. The survey asked questions about education, years of experience, location and age range. Other questions included the professionals understanding of communities of practice, the types of professional development explored within their workplace as well as other questions such as what they hoped to learn and gain from the upcoming communities of practice conference.

Having the survey come back before the symposium helps CFSA understand who their audience will be and what types of information will be most valuable to participants. Participants during the survey were able to comment about what they hoped to learn/gain from the symposium. This survey helped CFSA organize common activities participants are looking forward to.

The last form of data collection was focus groups conducted at the conference. Each participant was asked to list two ideas on a piece of paper of what they wish to see happen within their workplace whether professionally or personally. From there, research students were able to categorize those ideas into eight themes. Participants then had a chance to take part in small discussion groups in one of the eight themes to share their ideas about common topics such as leadership, networking, advocacy, mentoring, policies, parent involvement, directors and diversity.

Each table was asked to write down their ideas to use as data to further the research of communities of practice.

Communities of Practice Findings/Results

Research Question & Purpose of Study

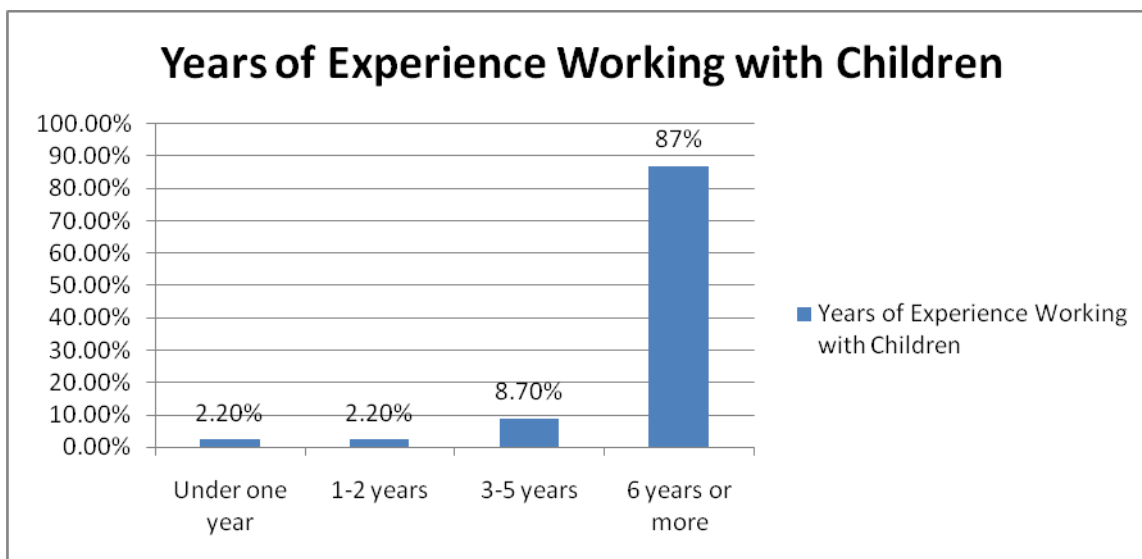
The research question was: What is the knowledge and implementation of communities of practice by early learning professionals? The purpose of the study is to determine what communities of practice is, what early learning practitioners know about communities of practice and if or how they implement it in their work.

Source of Data

The type of data that has been collected consists of both qualitative and quantitative data. Participants were asked to check boxes as well as write answers to questions. In order to collect this data, online surveys were sent out via email to all the participants who attended the Communities of Practice Conference. There were 88 surveys sent out and 47 surveys returned which is a return rate of 53%. Once at the conference there were discussion groups about the types of communities the participants would like to implement and then discussion on how they might make a community around the topic they came up with. There were 105 participants out of the 120 that were registered to come, which is a discussion rate of 87.5%. Within this 105 people there were six discussion groups conducted. Participants were able to move from group to group and some groups were as large as 20 while others were as small as three.

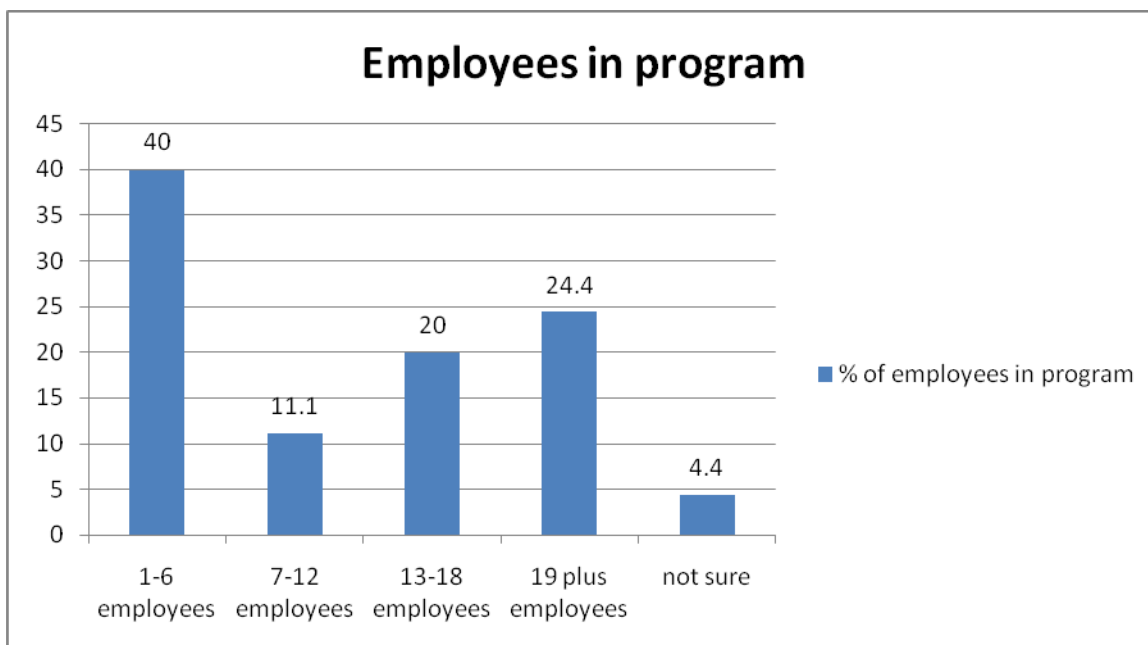
As shown in Figure 1, 87% of early learning professionals have six or more years of experience working with children. The smallest amounts of participants have been working with children under one year or within one to two years (2.2%).

Figure 1



In figure 2, a majority of programs (40%) only has one to six employees. The second highest number of employees with a program was 19 plus (24.4%).

Figure 2



As shown in Figure 3 a wide variety of agency roles were identified. A majority of participants were at the director level (27.7%). Smaller numbers identified as Child care worker, licencing officer, facilitators, associates and presidents of their own company each displaying 2.1% of

participants. The groups that were on the higher end represented were coordinators(14.9%), managers (10.6%). Common specific areas these roles laid within were daycare, preschool, out of school care and resource agency.

Figure 3

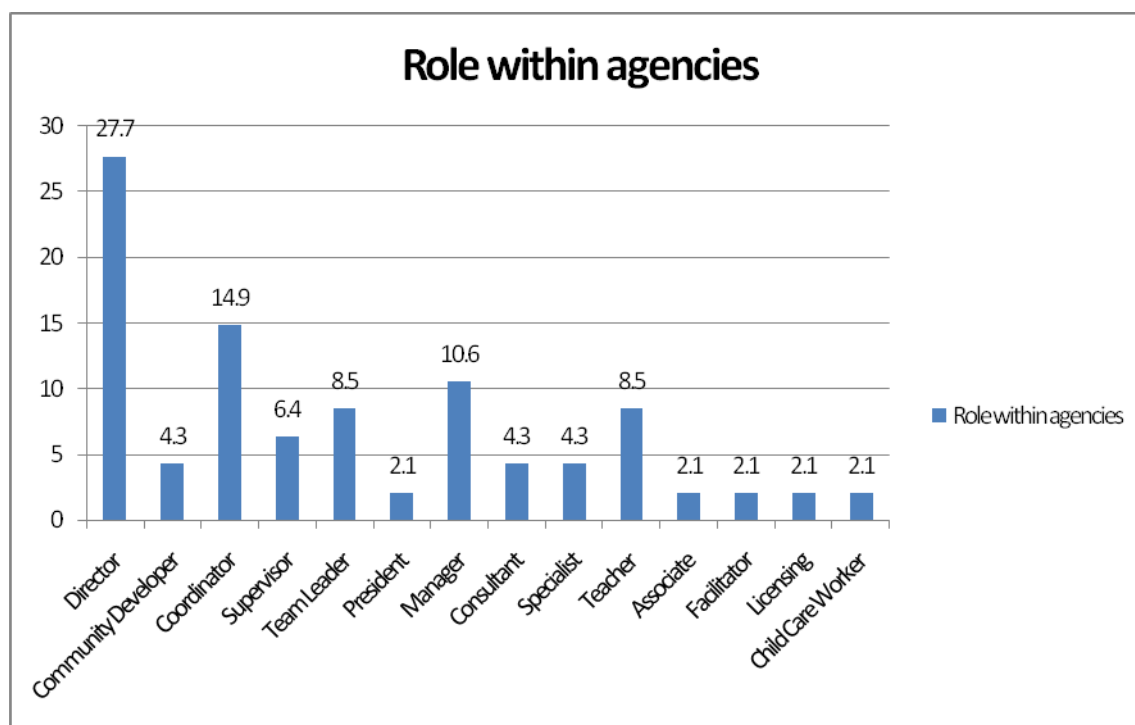
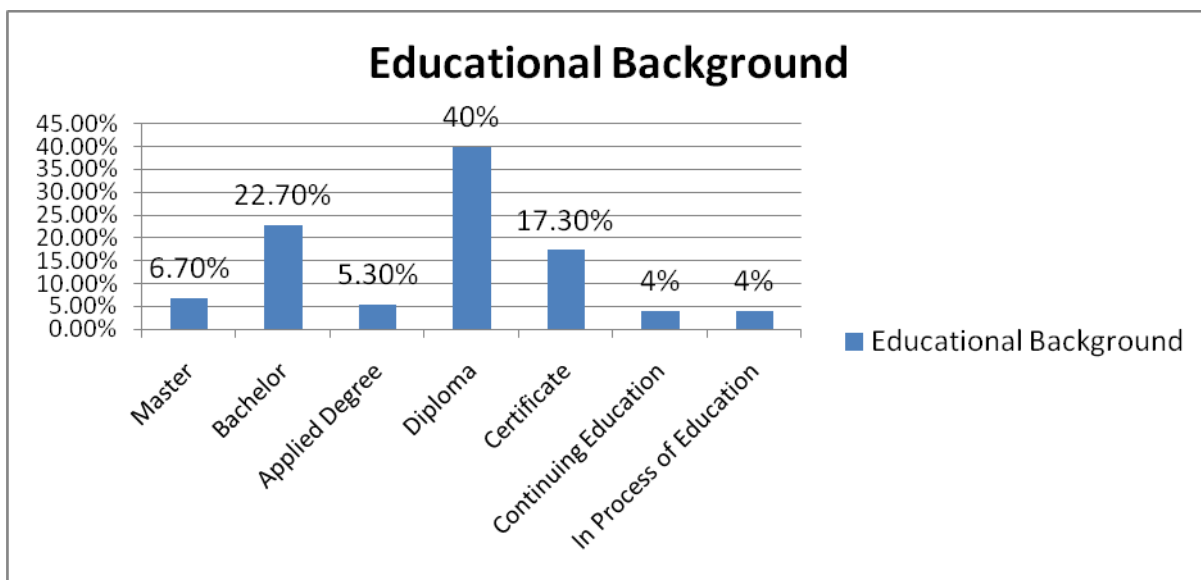


Figure 4 shows that the majority of participants hold a Diploma (40%). Fewer participants have completed their education through Continuing Education (4%) or are currently in the process of accomplishing their post-secondary education (4%). Some participants have obtained more than one form of post-secondary education which has also been calculated into these results. Some common areas of education were: Early Childhood Education, Education, Child Studies, Psychology and Social Work

Figure 4



Understanding of Communities of Practice

According to the survey, the majority of responders (86.7%) defined communities of practice as three main ideas:

- 1.) *Groups of people who get together to learn about a common passion or concern*
- 2.) *Engaging small groups of people who encourage people to maximize their own and each other's learning*
- 3.) *People who share beliefs, values, visions, develop leadership, participate in collective learning, support one another and share personal experiences/practices (Communities of Practice Survey).*

Many of the participants shared their thoughts and ideas before the symposium took place about what they hoped to learn and gain from the conference. Three main themes emerged from participants. They wanted to: network, learn, and finally have a better understanding of Communities of Practice (CoP).

Network: Many participants (50%) who shared their thoughts stressed networking as an important asset to gain. Connecting between communities, early childhood learning professionals, and the Calgary region was a main trend that professionals who attended the conference were looking for. One respondent commented:

...re-connecting the childcare community (frontline) to build upon our strengths to better support children, families and all professionals within Region 3. I believe we need to re-engage childcare workers to truly have a grass roots region.

One participant defined networking as:

meet[ing] with people who share similar concerns and/or passion for childcare and through ongoing interaction during and after the event deepen my own knowledge and expertise.

Learn: Another aspect of the conference participants were looking forward to was becoming part of the process. Participants wanted to learn on a professional level as one participant stated:

I hope to connect further in order to move our sector into a more cohesive framework that addresses issues and concerns through a broader more global perspective.

Others were looking to expand their knowledge as part of professional development. One participant said he/she wanted to:

...gain knowledge and information that is current, and practical.

Communities of Practice (CoP): It is true that while “Communities of Practice” is a new term, it is an old process. One participant wrote in the survey:

I hope that it is recognised that Communities of Practice are not new;

they have been in existence since the Middle Ages and have existed in the modern branding form for decades. This type of supportive, learning network is invaluable to the childcare sector but to engage in a true CoP we need to have open minds.

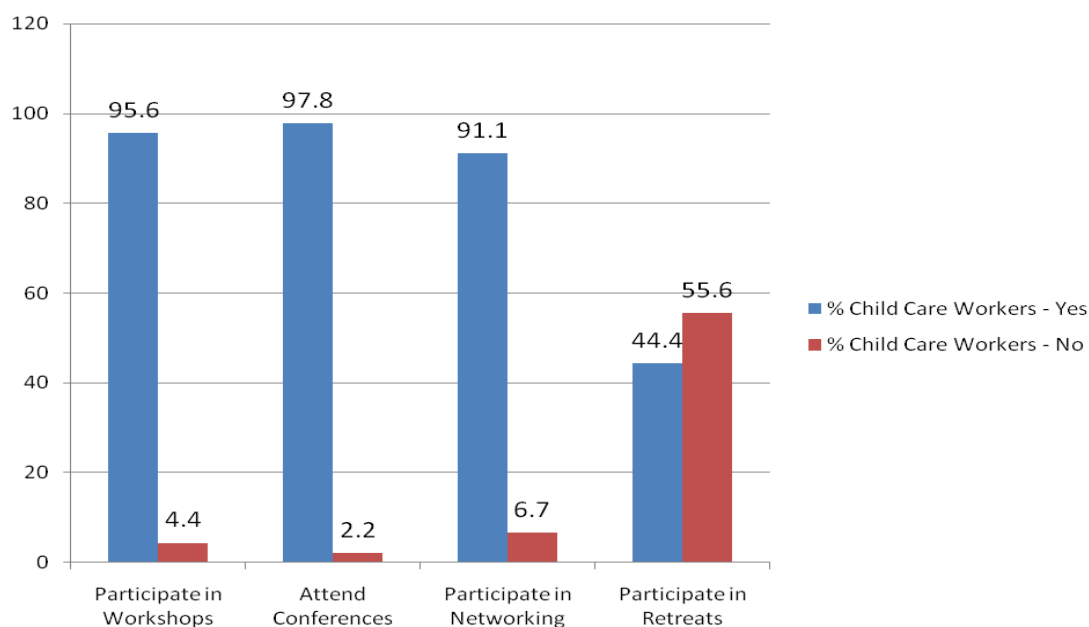
Generally participants were looking for:

...a better understanding of CoP and about the concept of CoP itself.

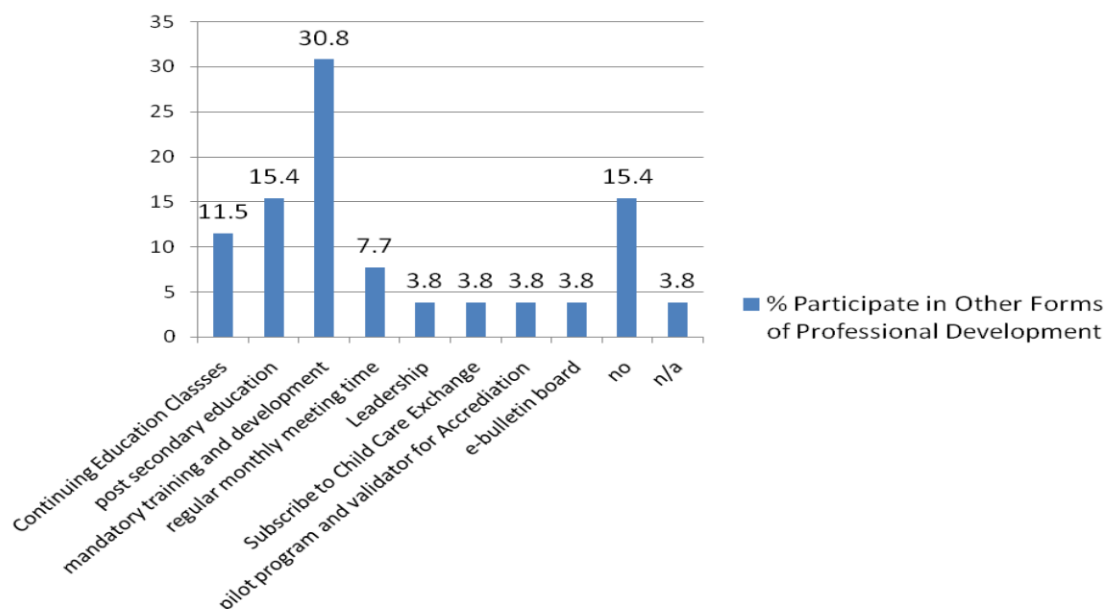
Participation and Forms of Professional Development

As shown in Figure 5 below, 95.6% of early learning professionals participate in various forms of professional development. Figure 6 shows that other forms of professional development that they participate in are mandatory training and development (30.8%), post secondary education (15.4%) and no other forms of professional development (15.4%).

Figure 5



Participation in Educational Professional Development



The survey indicated that participants attend similar workshops, such as ARCQE (Alberta Resource Centre for Quality Enhancement of Early Learning and Care Services), Children's Hospital workshops, and Aboriginal Awareness workshops. If the professionals are attending the same workshops they should be building communities of practice among each other because they must be going through some similar experiences if they are seeking similar workshops. There were also a few common conferences that were attended by the professionals, such as Parent Link Network conferences, Calgary Preschool Teachers Association conference, and various conferences with a basis of early childhood learning and development. The results also suggest that the early learning professionals network through community meetings, CRAQCC (Calgary Regional Association for Quality Child Care), and AFCCA (Alberta Family Child Care Association). Approximately 44% of early learning professionals participate in retreats. The

majority of the professionals stated that the retreats were based on team building and had guest speakers. One professional stated what his/her agency does for retreats:

*We do a Childcare Retreat within our Association for all of our
Childcare Centres to come together. We do one every other year.
We spend the weekend together and have several guest speakers.*

About 55% of the professionals do not participate in retreats within their agencies however, most professionals stated an interest in them. One professional stated:

We haven't planned one yet - but it is certainly on the agenda.

Another professional stated excitement about the possibility:

Would love to – no opportunity recently.

Early learning professionals have a fairly good understanding of communities of practice but may know the process by a different term. The survey shows that early learning professionals are engaging in professional development.

Discussion

Interpretation of Findings

In this survey it needs to be clear that the individuals that filled out the survey were attendees in a conference that was held about communities of practice. This survey did not represent the overall early learning professional population but rather a group of people who had an interest in learning more about the concept. Therefore some of the data in regard to knowledge may not be an accurate representation as some participants may have done their own research prior to attending the conference. After analysing the data we found that a majority of the data read

exceedingly clear. However, there were some observations that were made that need to be examined more carefully. In one of the first questions asked about the role within agency there were a variety of unclear answers. Some participants would answer with a basic title like owner or with two or three different positions. Rewording this question in a better way may have clarified the need for one position or role within the agency, which would have resulted in the data analysis being more specific of agency roles. Also, when roles were established in the survey a trend became clear. A vast majority of participants in the conference were directors or on the supervisor levels. It was questionable to why there weren't more front line childcare workers at the conference or if those were just the individuals that did not fill out the survey. On some questions (What region do you represent and what agency do you represent) there were a fair amount of participants that checked the other box. By giving participants more options or the opportunity to write in what the other meant we may have got a better understanding of their position.

When participants were asked to define what they thought communities of practice were, almost all respondents chose the same correct answer where only one chose "Unsure". This data shows that the concept of communities of practice is known among early learning professionals. It was also interesting to see that just under half of participants participate in retreats. Retreats are rarely spoken about as a term of professional development. It is often conferences and networking that professionals speak about attending. So to hear that early learning professionals utilize different form of professional development allows for more learning opportunities that other professionals may be aware of. Due to the fact that retreats are more time consuming and harder to find it is inspirational to see that these early learning professionals utilize these opportunities. Overall the participants that filled out the survey want to grasp a better

understanding of communities of practice as well learn to tools to help create and effective and appropriate community.

Implication of Study

By conducting this study a door of opportunity has been open for the organization that has requested this research be done. The organization now has a better understanding of what some early learning professionals know about communities of practice and how some of them have been implementing it in their practice already. The research also indicates that there are some early learning professionals who are unaware of the concept and what it might bring to their practice. With this knowledge the organization will now be able to move forward and look at providing the professionals with tools and guidance in developing their community. For the professionals who are unaware of the concept the organization brings them together with the professionals that have an understanding to help them build their own community. This allows the organization to move forward in continued research as well as how to move forward with promoting communities of practice among early learning professionals.

This study may have a lasting impact on the children with whom early learning professionals work with. If the early learning professionals can utilize the individuals within their community of practice then the professionals will no longer be guessing or avoiding a situation that they are unsure to handle. If a professional has some questions around a child that has Autism then that person can ask someone for advice or any information on how to work effectively with that child rather than working it out on their own. By professionals utilizing each others' skills and resources their effectiveness in their practice will increase therefore providing a better quality of care to the child they serve. Overall communities of practice provide the early learning professionals with the resources and information they need without outsourcing but using the

individuals within the early learning community. There are some professionals who have years of experience while others have the years of education and if the two of them are put together early learning professionals can grow their own practice as well as the others around them.

Recommendations

Conduct Post Survey: Conducting a post survey two weeks after the symposium would be great to gain insight of what the participants are doing after the symposium and if they are building communities of practice. Having a post survey would help to determine and measure if the participants gained knowledge from the symposium. A post survey would also help determine if the early learning professionals have broadened their understanding of communities of practice. Another positive of a post survey is to gain insight on the agencies and if they have increased their amount of participation in various communities of practice.

Utilize Each Other's Strengths: Based on educational levels and experience levels, professionals are encouraged to utilize each other's strengths rather than outsourcing. Taking advantage of what others have to offer builds stronger relationships and the ability to work closer with staff.

Regular Communication: Encouraging professionals within a community to meet regularly allow the advancement of practice. Meetings allow staff to come together and talk about issues that need to be addressed in the previous days. This can also be a time to talk about new ideas, or changes that may take place and share thoughts and opinions about how the agency is working.

Utilize Modern Technology: Utilizing modern technology is a good way to keep in contact with your community and avoid disconnection. It was mentioned in the group activity that Facebook could be used to keep people in regular contact with each other. Another way to avoid

disconnection is to use Teleconferences to have meetings and discussions to stay up to date with what is occurring in your agency and others that affect your profession

Annual Conferences: Implementing annual conferences are beneficial to all professionals in a number of ways. First, during conferences professionals are able to obtain more information about topics that they would like to know more about. Second, professionals are able to talk about issues and ideas that they may have with other professionals and receive feedback/support. Third, at conferences professionals are able to address community services that are in need as well wanted that may not be at the moment available.

Focus on Professional Development: In order to work with today's communities, early childhood learning professionals must be able to stay on pace with new information such as research, findings, or technology that become available. Professional development (ex. retreats) may also play a part in building a stronger working agency when everyone is able to come together.

Final Thoughts

This research is only the beginning stages and therefore there should be more research conducted. Looking at what the early learning professionals have implemented into their practice after the conference will be an essential part to the continued research. Using the information that may be gathered from these individuals will assist in creating communities of practice guidelines for future early learning professionals. There are working professionals who already utilize this concept; it is now putting it all together and building communities of practice a reputation. The authors of this research look forward to seeing more research conducted within this area and where it will take early learning professionals in their practice.

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Appendices

Appendix A – Communities of Practice Symposium Participants Letter

Dear Conference Participant,

If you have already completed the following survey, Thank you! and we look forward to seeing you at the conference.

If you have not had a moment to complete the survey, could you please take a few minutes and complete this 15 question survey by **March 12th. 2009**. To access the survey, simply click on the following link (or paste it into your server) and login with the password: learn

In preparation for the March 13th & 14th '*Communities of Practice*' Conference, hosted by the **Calgary and Area, Child and Family Services Authority**, students from a Child Studies Research course at Mount Royal College have developed a survey to collect some preliminary, anonymous information from conference participants. This information will help inform the symposium developers about the participant's prior understanding of 'communities of practice' as well as their current professional development experiences.

To access the survey, simply click on the following link (or paste in into your server) and login with the password: learn

<https://www.toofast.ca/takesurvey.php?SurveyID=1445>

password: learn

On behalf of the students and myself, thank you for your participation - we look forward to further discussion at the symposium.

Sincerely,

Cathy Smey Carston, PhD (c)
Faculty/ Program Coordinator
Early Learning and Child Care Program
Department of Child and Youth Studies
Mount Royal College
(403) 440-6447

QUALITY CHILD CARE KEEPS CANADA WORKING!

Appendix B – Survey Questions

List of Questions for Survey "Communities of Practice Symposium"

Number	Question	Type
Question 1	What is your title or role within your program/agency?	Long Answer Separate each option with semi-colons
Question 2	What is your educational background?	Long Answer Separate each option with semi-colons
Question 3	How many years of experience working with children do you have?	Multiple Choice Under 1 year;1-2 years;3-5 years;6 years or more
Question 4	What type of program/agency do you represent?	Multiple Choice and Long Answer Day Care;School Age Care;Family Childcare (eg.dayhomes);Resource Agency;Preschool;Other (please specify)
Question 5	What area of the region is your program based in?	Multiple Choice CalgarySW;CalgarySE;CalgaryNW;CalgaryNE;RuralE;RuralW;RuralN;RuralS;Other
Question 6	How many employees are in your program?	Multiple Choice 1-6 ;7-12 ;13-18 ;19 plus;I am not sure
Question 7	What are the ages of children served in your program?	Multiple Choice and Long Answer 0-6 years;6-12 years ;0-12 years;Other (please specify)
Question 8	The following questions pertain to the professional development opportunities offered within your agency; Please indicate what type of professional development you and your staff are currently involved in?	Separate each option with semi-colonsYes/No and Long Answer

	- - Do you and/or your agency staff participate in workshops? If yes, please give an example of a recent workshop.	
Question 9	Do you and/or your program staff attend conferences? If yes, please list an example of a recent conference attended.	Separate each option with semi-colons Yes/No and Long Answer
Question 10	Do you and/or your program staff participate in networking? If yes, please provide an example of a recent networking opportunity or experience.	Separate each option with semi-colons Yes/No and Long Answer
Question 11	Do you and/or your program staff participate in retreats? If yes, please provide a brief description of a recent retreat.	Separate each option with semi-colons Yes/No and Long Answer
Question 12	Do you and/or your program participate in any other forms of professional development not already listed above?	Long Answer Separate each option with semi-colons
Question 13	Choose one of the following descriptions listed below that represents your current understanding of 'communities of practice'.	Multiple Choice Groups of people who get together to learn about a common passion or concern; Engaging small groups of people who encourage people to maximize their own and each others learning; People who share beliefs, values, visions, develop leadership, participate in collective learning,

		support one another and share personal experiences/practices; ;All of the above; None of the above; I am not sure
Question 14	What do you hope to learn/gain from the upcoming "Communities of Practice" symposium?	Long Answer Separate each option with semi-colons
Question 15	Any other comments or suggestions about the upcoming symposium?	Long Answer Separate each option with semi-colons

Appendix C – Communities of Practice Conference Advertisement



Calgary and Area Child and Family Services invites you to attend a

Community of Practice Conference

**When: Friday Evening, March 13, 2009 from 6:00 to 9:00
and Saturday March 14 from 8:30 to 4:30**

Where: The ATCO Centre at Canada Olympic Park (free parking)

Learn about what a community of practice is and how we can use a community of practice to strengthen and support our child care community. Help to brainstorm about how we can develop a community of practice within our region!

On Friday evening, enjoy a lovely dinner and listen to Dr. Chaya Kulkarni from Invest in Kids and the Toronto Sick Kids Hospital share her experiences with communities of practice in her work with child care communities across the country.

On Saturday learn about how to foster collaboration and enhance networking from Bob Chartier, learn about the latest research in mentoring and leadership from Cathy Smey Carston, and engage in a panel discussion with some of our local leaders as they talk about some of the various collaborative initiatives currently underway in our region.

Receive resources that you can share with your colleagues!

Seats are limited for this free event

**RSVP to Joanne Baxter on or before March 9, 2009 at
403-440-6492 or jbaxter@mtroyal.ca**

Schedule of Events:

Friday March 13

- 6:00 – 6:30 Registration and meet and greet
- 6:30 – 6:45 Welcome from Calgary and Area Child and Family Services and Children and Youth Services
- 6:45 Dinner
- 7:30 – 9:00 Keynote Address: Chaya Kulkarni: **Communities of Practice to Support our Child Care Community**

Saturday March 14

- 8:30 Registration and Breakfast
- 9:00 – 9:15 Opening Remarks from Calgary and Area Child and Family Services
- 9:15 – 10:00 Bob Chartier: **Fostering Collaboration and Mentoring**
- 10:00 – 10:45 Group Activity
- 10:45 – 11:00 Coffee
- 11:00 – 12:00 Cathy Smey Carston: **Current Trends in Mentoring and Leadership in Child Care**
- 12:00 – 1:00 Lunch
- 1:00 – 2:15 Panel Discussion
- 2:15 - 2:30 Coffee
- 2:30 – 4:00 Group activity:
- 4:00 – 4:30 Presentation to large group
- 4:30 Farewell and Thank you

